

Session 24: The Oppression of Dinah

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov's sons begin to repeat his deceptive pattern.
- The Bible depicts the reality of human evil and the apparent absence of God, mirroring our lived experience and forcing us to confront how we ought to respond.

Yaaqov's Sons Among the Nations

This tragic and disturbing story shows how Yaaqov's sons not only repeat their father's deceptive patterns, but escalate them to catastrophic results. In the overall organization of the Yaaqov story, this narrative corresponds to its compositional pair, the story of Yitskhaq's deception of the nations in [Genesis 26](#).

The story has an elegant large-scale design.

Genesis 33:18-20

- Now **Yaaqov came safely to the city of Shechem** ... and he bought the piece of land where he had pitched his tent from the hand of the sons of Hamor, Shechem's father ... and **he set up an altar and called it El-Elohe-Israel.**

Genesis 34:1-7

34:1-4

Shechem Rapes Dinah and Seeks To Marry Her

- Hyperlinks to Genesis 2-3 and 6
- **34:2 Shechem's dishonorable action**: "he lay with her and he oppressed her"
- **34:4** Son speaks to father: "Get this little girl for me to marry"

34:5-7

Father Yaaqov's Non-Response vs. Yaakov's Sons' Response of Anger

- **34:5** "Yaaqov heard ... and he kept silent"
- **34:7** "The sons of Yaaqov heard ... and they were grieved and were very angry"

Genesis 34:8-24

34:8-19a

Father Hamor and Son Shechem Propose a Marriage Alliance With Yaaqov's Family

- a - 34:8-12 **Hamor and Shechem's speech: "give us your daughters/take our daughters for wives"**
- b - 34:14-17 Yaaqov's sons' deceptive speech: "we will consent (אוֹת) if you are circumcised like us"
- c - 34:18-19a **Hamor and Shechem consent**

34:19b-24

Father Hamor and Son Shechem Propose a Marriage Alliance to the People of Shechem

- a - 34:21-23 **Hamor and Shechem's speech: "will take/give daughters ... for wives "**
- b - Hamor and Shechem's qualifier: "they will consent (אוֹת) if we are circumcised as they are"
- c - 34:24 **People of Shechem consent**

Genesis 34:25-31

Simeon and Levi Murder the Town of Shechem

- Hyperlinks to Genesis 4 and 6
- Narrative of **Simeon and Levi's dishonorable actions**
- 34:30 Father to sons: "You have brought trouble upon me"
- 34:31 Sons speak to father: "Should he treat our sister as a prostitute?"

Genesis 35:1

- And God said to **Yaaqov, "Arise, go up to Bethel** and dwell there, and **make an altar there to El** , who appeared to you when you fled from your brother Esau."

Genesis 33:18-35:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

This story has an important match in Genesis 26 (also in the middle of the first part of the Yaaqov story).

Yitskhaq and the Canaanites (Genesis 26:1-35)

Rivqah is seized by an innocent Canaanite **because of** Yitskhaq's deception

Yaaqov and the Hivites (Genesis 34:1-31)

Dinah is seized by a deceptive Canaanite, **which results in** Simeon and Levi's even worse deception

Yitskhaq, Canaanites, Hivities. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yitskhaq and the Canaanites (Genesis 26:1-35)	Yaaqov and the Hivites (Genesis 34:1-31)
Gen. 26:10 “One of the people barely laid (כמעט שכב) with your wife and brought guilt (אשם) upon us”	Gen. 34:2 “Shechem saw [Dinah] ... and laid (וישכב) with her and raped her (ויענה)”
Gen. 20 Like father, like son: Yitskhaq lies about Rivqah and replays his father’s same deception of Abimelech	Gen. 34:5 “Yaaqov heard that [Shechem] had defiled (טמא) Dinah”
Gen. 26:10 “ One of the people (אחד העם) barely laid with your wife”	Gen. 34:13 Like father, like son: Simeon and Levi plan “with deception” (במרמה) just as their father Yaaqov acted “with deception” (במרמה) toward Esau (Gen. 27:35)
Yitskhaq calls his wife “sister”	Gen. 34:16 “they will give their daughters to us, and we will take their daughters for ourselves ... and we will become one people (לעם אחד)”
Gen. 26:28-29, 31 Yitskhaq and Abimelech make a covenant (ברית) so that Yitskhaq can depart in peace (בשלום)	Shechem lays with the “sister” of the sons of Yaaqov
Gen. 26:22 “And he named the well Rehoboth (רחבות), and he said, ‘Because Yahweh has made wide (רחב) for us”	Gen. 34:21a Shechem and Hamor to the Shechemites: “Behold these [Hebrew] men are peaceful (שלמים) with us”
	Gen. 34:21b “... and the land is wide (רחבת) of hands before them”
Yitskhaq, Canaanites, Hivites. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

The Rape of Dinah in Shechem

18 And Yaaqov came in peace to **the city** of **Sh'khem** in the land of **Canaan** when he came from Paddan-aram and he camped facing **the city**.

19 And he acquired the portion of **a field** where he had stretched out his tent there, from the hand of **Khamor, father of Sh'khem** for 100 Qesitah,

20 and he set up there an altar, and he called it,

34:1 And **Dinah** went out,
the **daughter of Leah**,
whom she had birthed for **Yaaqov**,
to see **the daughters** of the land.
2 And **Sh'khem** saw her,
and the son of **Khamor the Khivite**
and exalted one of the land,
and **he took** her
and **he laid down with her**,
and he oppressed her.
3 And his being clung to **Dinah**,
daughter of Yaaqov,
and he loved the young woman,
and he spoke to the heart of the young woman.
4 And **Sh'khem** said to **Khamor his father**, saying,
“**Take** for me this girl as a wife.”

5 And **Yaaqov** **heard** that **he had defiled** **Dinah his daughter**,
and **his sons** were with his herds in **the field**,
and **Yaaqov** remained silent until they came.
6 And **Khamor, father of Sh'khem**, came out to **Yaaqov** to speak with him.
7 And **the sons of Yaaqov** came in from **the field** **when they heard**,
and the men were grieved,
and there was hot-anger to them, very much,
because **he had done a despicable act** in Israel,
by laying down with the daughter of Yaaqov,
and such **a thing should not be done**.

Genesis 33:18-34:7. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The Promise of the Land

Near the end of the Abraham story, he purchases the only piece of land in Canaan that he ever owns: the field with the burial cave of Macpelah (see [Gen. 23](#)). The story focuses on the friendly relationship between Abraham and the Canaanites, who esteem him as one “exalted by *Elohim*” (נשיא אלהים, [Gen. 23:6](#)). They peacefully negotiate a price for the field, and it becomes the down payment of the land promised by God.

Now, near the end of Yaaqov's story, he also purchases a small field outside the Canaanite city of Shechem. All seems well. But next, Hamor of Shechem, who is “exalted in the land” (נשיא הארץ, [Gen. 34:2](#)), sexually attacks Yaaqov's daughter, and this leads to Yaaqov owning the whole city through murder and violence. The stories could not be more opposite.

Reflection Question

How can we process the parts of the Bible that make us angry? What does it look like to think responsibly about these stories?